



HELLEBORE

Dr Dee's [OTTOMAN] ADVENTURE

by **Matthew Melvin-Koushki**



IN THE ANNALS of British occultism, there is no figure more famous, or more infamous, than Dr. John Dee (1527–1608). This patriotic Anglo-Welsh mage, Cambridge renaissance man, advisor to Queen Elizabeth I and coiner of the term “British Empire” has sharply divided opinion for the last four centuries due to his devotion to alchemy, astrology, kabbalah and magic—and especially his fervent trafficking with angels. Although celebrated now by historians of science and historians of empire, he was (and is) lampooned as Marlowe’s Doctor Faustus and Shakespeare’s Prospero, destined to be damned for his occult-scientific dealings with the Devil. Such polemics cast a pall over Dee’s career and stymied all his many bids for patronage in England and throughout Europe; he died depressed and in debt, his magnificent library destroyed. But what if our frustrated British Faust had continued east, to Istanbul, following his merchant countrymen, seeking patronage at the more occult-friendly Ottoman court?



ALTHOUGH counterfactual, such a scenario is not historically implausible. English-Ottoman relations were unprecedentedly warm during the Elizabethan era, and the population of the Ottoman Empire itself—aka New Byzantium—was majority Christian. This is despite the dread fascination Ottoman imperial expansion into Europe inspired among the English public, as well as the apocalyptic ethos of both societies. For many 16th-century observers, Christian or Muslim, the end times were clearly at hand—so the practice of magic boomed throughout Islamdom and Christendom alike as a means of controlling history.

A sworn Christian cosmopolite, variously Catholic and Protestant but dedicated to the destruction of the “Great Turk” as Antichrist, John Dee emblematised the spirit of anti-Ottoman apocalyptic magic.

At the same time, his increasingly desperate quest for imperial patronage—without which he could not realize his universalist scientific-imperial project to mathematically riddle the cosmos and so usher in the millennium—could have led him to cut his European losses as a last resort. Had he done so, the turncoat Welshman would likely have found his Ottoman reception to be more enthusiastic, empowering and profitable than any other of his experience. Every one of his polymagical interests were current in Ottoman courtly circles to a giddy extent, and his new brand of Enochian angel-summoning of more immediate Islamic scholarly salience, with vaster library collections to match. In contrast to Latin Christendom, specifically Enochian forms of occultism were simply the order of the day throughout the 16th-century Persianate world. Demonology was virtually nonexistent and angel-talk perfectly kosher, indeed already an important scientific basis for empire. It was Dee’s dream come true.

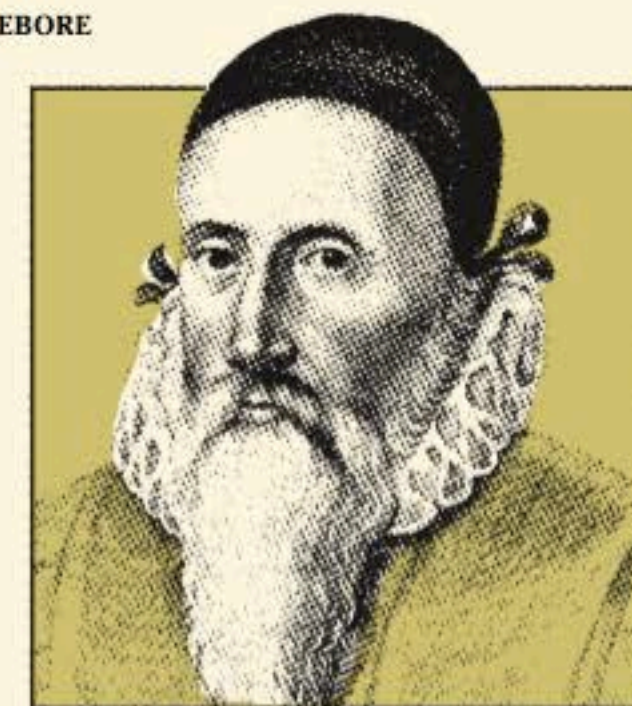
A One-World Scientific-Imperialist Project

Dee’s attempt to unify all the natural and mathematical sciences under the rubric of alchemy, astrology and kabbalah, on the one hand, and his vision of a British (or Habsburg) world empire as millennial utopia, on the other, must be understood as a single project: the chrysopoetic transmutation of the iron of science and the lead of state by means of the Monad, to hermetically marry heaven to earth and so accomplish (as per Isaac Newton’s translation of the Emerald Tablet) “the miracles of one only thing.” Three works in particular epitomise this project.

Most influential, and also most impenetrable, is his *Monas hieroglyphica*, printed in Antwerp in 1564. Its self-proclaimed mathematical, magical, kabbalistic and anagogic unification of all knowledge in a single astrological-chemical symbol—the Hieroglyphic Monad—produced perhaps the most recognizable glyph in all of early modern British occultism. It remains ubiquitous in modern Euro-American occulture too.

Dee’s stridently Pythagorean masterwork is dedicated to the Holy Roman Emperor Maximilian II (r. 1527–76) to prompt him to invade the Ottoman Empire and so bring about Christ’s return and the end of history. Maximilian remained unconvinced, however, as did his successor Rudolf II (r. 1576–1612), as well as Elizabeth I (r. 1533–1603) herself, none of whom found Dee’s analysis actionable, or even comprehensible. His dream of a Habsburg triumph over the encroaching Ottomans was not to be.

But Dee’s dream of a bihemispheric British Empire was to be, though well after the fact. In his *Brytanici imperii limites*, or *The Limits of the British Empire*, of 1576, our Londoner stakes an astonishingly bold claim to the North American continent



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He dride the black paper, and so the yelke called d. Appear
 upon garment and out, in shape of the letter in black. after the manner
 and in of this garment and properties.

Α Ω Γ Ε Ζ Σ Ζ Δ Υ Β Β
 ✓ Γ Δ Ε Ζ Γ Δ Ε Ζ



Above: Portraits of Dee and Muhammad in the frontispiece to Causabon's 1659 *A True & Faithful Relation of What Passed for Many Yeers Between Dr. John Dee and Some Spirits*

as Arthurian patrimony: for King Arthur himself, as well as other English, Welsh and Scottish potentates and saints, had "discovered" the New World well before Columbus. Legally, therefore, the British claim must supersede the Spanish. Here again, Elizabeth declined to act on his passionate urging. But his cartographic services to the crown did provide an early scientific and ideological impetus to British imperialisation nonetheless—and may have something to do with the fact that the present article is written not in Spanish or Turkish, but English!

The history of empire—especially of the European colonialist variety—is inextricable from the history of science, and science from empire. Dee stands poster child for this equation. While his *Monas hieroglyphica* found limited currency until the Golden Dawn movement of the 19th century, and his *Brytanici imperii limites* was largely ignored in its own day and after, it is his 1570 *Præface* to the first English translation of the *Elements of Euclid*, that foundational textbook of geometry, that best represents his contemporary fame as a Pythagoreanising mathematician with a patriotic commitment to imperial science. Encompassing such ancient and modern sciences as astronomy, astrology, music, perspective, anthropography, helicosophy, horometry, architecture, navigation and thaumaturgy, the *Præface* proposes a new classificatory scheme (the Groundplat) predicated on a specifically Pythagorean, kabbalistic conception of the world as a mathematical text, to be decoded, and magically recoded, by the natural philosopher. Most revolutionary is Dee's presentation of a crowning universal mathematical science, *archemastrie*, simultaneously alchemical, astrological, magical and kabbalistic, and above all experimentalist. It shares the ethos of his contemporaries Francis Bacon (d. 1626) and Johannes Kepler (d. 1630) in particular,

as well as Isaac Newton (d. 1727) after them, each rigorously mathematising and experimentalist occultists too.

Where Dee parted ways with these Saints of Science is in his commitment to conversing with angels. During the 1580s, he pursued these conversations with the shady, debauched but talented skryer and alchemist Edward Kelley, who was able to summon the angels into his divining crystals on a daily basis. He accompanied Dee on his ill-fated tour of the Continent in quest of patronage. Although all sessions were recorded with exhaustive precision, the bulk of these records has been lost, both through the inattention of posterity and Dee's own burning of years' worth of notebooks in a fit of pique when the world failed to end in '88 as the angels foretold (he assumed, clearly incorrectly, they meant 1588). A critical mass survived nevertheless, and was published in 1659 by Meric Causabon. Originally meant as a means to damn Dee for his gullibility—indeed, Causabon associates Dee with the Prophet Muhammad on the frontispiece as a fellow converser with angels—it came to form the basis of Enochian magic to the present.

What has been lost in the modern occultist retrieval of Dee's *Spiritual Diaries*, however, is their overtly apocalyptic tenor. His angelic interlocutors, via the unreliable Kelley, often urge war against the reigning Ottoman sultan, Murad III (r. 1574–95), as Antichrist, or predict the end of the world, interspersing gobbets of scientific insight. Yet the angels do not seem to be particularly pro-Catholic or pro-Protestant either, but rather most interested in the establishment of a millennial world empire at all costs. Although the angels did not divulge this fact to Dee, the Ottoman house had nurtured the same millenarian and occultist imperial vision since the turn of the 16th century.

Dee Finally Finds Satisfaction at the Ottoman Court

So what if Dee, desperate for patronage yet panned as a demonist, had in fact turned to the Ottoman "Dark Side" after unending failure to win either English or Habsburg support for his imperial science? The English-Ottoman free trade agreement instituted by Elizabeth meant that a disillusioned Dee could have found easy passage to the Ottoman capital. In the 1580s and '90s he was in dire financial straits more than ever, and the angels had changed their minds before, often threatening Christian sovereigns with removal for their sins. Perhaps the Great Turk was no Antichrist after all, but savior?

More than any of his inconstant and stingy Christian patrons, religion aside, Murad III was a man after our mage's own heart. The Ottoman sultan was a Sufi initiate devoted to oneiromancy, astrology, physiognomy and talismanry, as well as to lettrism, the Islamic sister science to Jewish kabbalah, and similarly concerned with the mathematical-linguistic riddling of the cosmos as a second scripture. All these sciences were explicitly based on the harnessing of angels as bearers of divine speech. As the only Ottoman sultan whose reign spanned the Islamic millennium (1592 CE), Murad fashioned himself a prophet-saint-king on the strength of his personal exploration of the spiritual realms. His detailed diaries—reminiscent of Dee's own—show him to have been the frequent recipient of divine, angelic, prophetic and saintly communications, the Beloved (*murad*) of God, served by the archangels Gabriel and Michael like Muhammad himself.

In his occult-technological predilections, however, Murad was continuing the court culture established by his more glorious dynastic forebears, Bayezid II (r. 1481-1512), Selim the Grim (r. 1512-20) and especially Süleyman the Magnificent (r. 1520-66). The latter fashioned himself

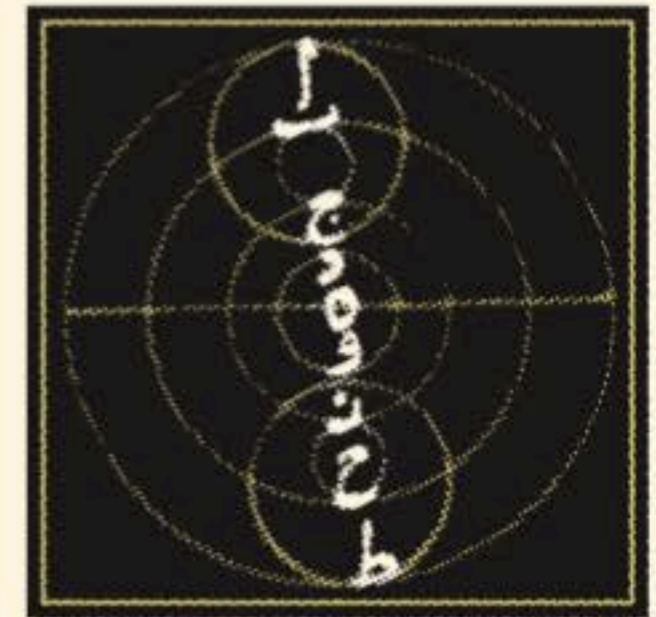
the second King Solomon and Alexander the Great, who overmastered the previous Holy Roman Emperor, Charles V (r. 1519-66), as millennial sovereign, expectant host of Jesus and the end of time, as proved by lettrist prognostication. This new brand of millennial, monist-universalist sovereignty, predicated on a deep, occult-scientific reading of history and the cosmos, was moreover common to the early modern Persianate world as a whole—in sharp contrast to the Latinate. The Mughal Emperor Akbar (r. 1556-1605) was arguably its most successful avatar in his role as astrocratic god-king, his talismanic body marrying heaven to earth, Muslim to Hindu, Jain to Christian, to create modern India, the many become One. That the British Raj adopted Akbar's manual of empire wholesale is a historical irony that has yet to be fully appreciated. By comparison, Ottoman imperial apocalypticism had mellowed since its mid-16th-century heyday, albeit revived somewhat by Murad III. As that may be, Dee would likely have found its continued Jesus-centric and kabbalistic ecumenism unexpectedly congenial, and would certainly have thrilled at the prospect of serving a fellow angelologist and eschatologist as royal patron.

Equally thrilling to Dee would have been the prospect of finally riddling the mystery of his beloved if garbled "Arabic book," the *Book of Soyga* (Greek *Agios*, "holy", spelled backward, Arabic-style), which the angel Uriel reported to be revealed to Adam, and explicable only by the archangel Michael, who never got around to explicating it. Its alternate title, *Aldaraia* (from Arabic *al-diraya*, "understanding"), as well as its appended kabbalistic magic squares, common in contemporary Arabic and Persian grimoires but not in Latin ones, confirms the book's Islamic origin. The vast Bunian-Bistamian magical corpus, popular in Ottoman courtly and scholarly circles, likely served as source or model for his book, and is predicated on a basic Islamic lettrist principle, one so dear to Dee too:

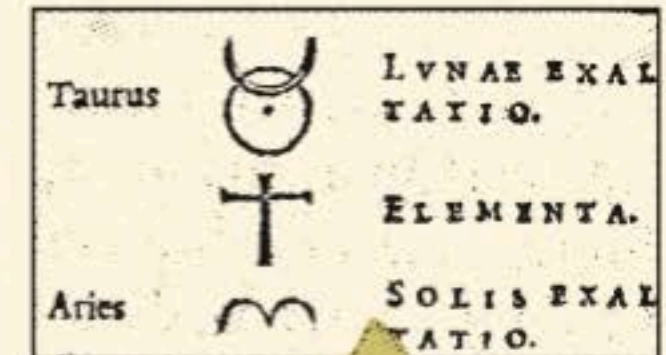
angels are real, mathematical constructs to be talismanically harnessed and infinitely multiplied by means of magic squares based on divine names. Either way, Dee would have been entranced by the sheer profusion and availability of occult books in the Ottoman realms, where even public libraries dwarfed his private one back in England by an order of magnitude.

Had he become privy to Ottoman manuscript holdings through a translator, Dee would likely have encountered the Islamic answer to his Hieroglyphic Monad too: the Tahawi Circle of Ibn Turka (d. 1432), foremost occult philosopher of Timurid Iran, whose strictly *Pythagorean Book of Investigations* (*Kitab al-Mafahis*) had been in demand in Istanbul for a century and a half. Like Dee did the Monad, Ibn Turka presents the Circle as sigil summarising his life's work and epitome of his new, mathematising cosmology. Simply put, this Isfahani sage-mage is best approached as a Timurid Dr. Dee—or Dee best approached as an Elizabethan Dr. Littleturk. Both men were committed to the mathematical, magical, kabbalistic, alchemical and anagogic unification of all knowledge in the service of millenarian, one-world empire. And both were smeared for their imperialist efforts in their own day, but became more influential in death.

Unlike Dee's life project, however, Ibn Turka's paid off scientifically more immediately. Among the three Timurid sovereigns he sought to cultivate as Alexandrian philosopher-kings was Ulugh Beg (r. 1409-49), the most famous sultan-scientist in Islamic history, whose Samarkand Observatory was responsible for the most accurate star tables produced in the Western tradition to date—so accurate that they were still being used in London in the 19th century. This Persianate mathematisation of astronomy, and hence of astrology, was part and parcel of the Latinate "Scientific Revolution", as historians have now shown. Indeed, Dee's reclassification of astrology from



Ibn Turka's Tahawi Circle (*Kitab al-Mafahis*, Tehran, MS Majlis 10196, f. 63a)



Mughal Emperor Akbar

the natural to the mathematical sciences was an unprecedented move in Latin, but had already been done in Persian four centuries before. The lettrist and kabbalist push to mathematise the cosmos as a whole helped fuel this paradigm shift.

No More Doctor Faust

Needless to say, the path to imperial patronage has rarely run smooth. But the British Dee would have bid fairer to win his rightful boons at the cosmopolitan Ottoman court than he actually did at the niggling English or Habsburg courts, neither of which were as devoted to angelology as their more powerful, and more millenarian, "Saracenic" counterpart. At the very least, he certainly would never have been disparaged as a demonist.



A turncoat Dr. John Dee—as Kara Yahya Efendi ("Dee" being Welsh for "black")—might have blended into Ottoman society so well as to lose his hard-earned notoriety altogether.

There was no witchhunting in Islam. His system of Enochian magic in particular would have slotted quite comfortably into the already large and growing Enochian occultist tradition in the Islamic world, to be distinguished only by its dogged, scientific completeness. (Enoch, or the quranic prophet Idris, was the patron saint of as many occult sciences as Hermes himself, such that the two were often identified by Muslim scholars.) Similarly, his powerful advocacy of Paracelsian alchemy would have anticipated its Ottoman vogue by only a few decades. The *Monas hieroglyphica* itself, translated into Arabic and rededicated to Murad III, would have been avidly read and commented on by lettrists and alchemists throughout the Persianate world, scene to a parallel "Occult-Scientific Revolution" from the Mongol period onward.

That Dee's name has instead become synonymous with Enochian magic specifically and suspect witchery generally is, ironically enough, a product of 19th-century British colonialist anti-occultist chauvinism. This ideology was already foretold by his dramatic transformation into Faust as early as the 1590s. In his *Tragicall History of the Life and Death of Doctor Faustus*, Christopher Marlowe (d. 1593) equates Dee's kabbalism with demon-dealing in this speech:

Divinity, adieu!

These metaphysics of magicians,
And necromantic books are heavenly;
Lines, circles, scenes, letters, and characters;
Ay, these are those that Faustus most desires.
O, what a world of profit and delight,
Of power, of honour, of omnipotence,
Is promis'd to the studious artizan!

Later in the play, before his final damnation, Faust/Dee successfully summons the shade of Alexander the Great for Charles V, Holy Roman Emperor—the playwright's sneering nod to his subject's imperial occultist project.

To finally clear his name, let us try to understand Dee as he understood himself. In Spenglerian terms, this harbinger of modern Faustian civilization did not identify as a Faust at all, but was more at home in the Magian civilization that birthed it. And Islamdom, wonderfully free of witch-hunts, epitomised Magianism in Dee's day and through the (British) colonial era. As the most studiously lettrist of artisans in search of millenarian patronage, our imperialist Anglo-Welsh mage might well have found a world more full of profit and power in the early modern Persianate world than he did in his native Latinate. Whom better to court than the Ottoman sovereign, a fellow angelologist and eschatologist, or fashion into an Arthur and Alexander combined, with a military view to the west?



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